

In late 2022, we saw the rise of ChatGPT, an AI chatbot that swiftly captured global attention. It introduced AI with its powers unleashed truly and transformed AI's role in society. The man behind this transformation is Sam Altman, CEO of OpenAI. Known for his foresight and strategic decisions, Altman has led OpenAI from its origins as a non-profit research lab to a commercial powerhouse at the centre of artificial intelligence innovation. Many have vilified him, and many have celebrated his leadership in a new future where our lives are more intertwined with AI than we could ever imagine. This duality is what makes Sam Altman's tryst with AI, his role in the development of OpenAI, and the currently ongoing shift in focus from greater good to commercial success interesting!

Early leadership and vision

Before taking the helm at OpenAI, Altman was already an influential figure in Silicon Valley. His early career is a key factor in understanding his role in shaping OpenAI's trajectory. Altman co-founded the location-based social networking app Loopt in 2005 at the age of 19. Although Loopt was eventually acquired, Altman's entrepreneurial experience earned him a spot in the prestigious startup accelerator Y Combinator (YC). YC is often hailed as one of the most influential forces behind the modern startup ecosystem, having helped launch companies like Dropbox, Airbnb, and Reddit. Altman's leadership at Y Combinator, where he served as president from 2014 to 2019, gave him the strategic insight needed to navigate complex technical landscapes and manage the rapid scaling of ventures—skills that would later prove invaluable at OpenAI.

Altman's vision for AI was bold and audacious from the start: to create Artificial General Intelligence (AGI) that would benefit all of humanity. AGI represents a form of AI capable of understanding, learning, and applying intelligence across a broad range of tasks at a level that matches or surpasses human intelligence. Altman's emphasis on AGI from early on set OpenAI apart from other research institutions that focused more on narrow, task-specific AI. AGI has remained a distant, almost mythical goal in the world of AI development, but Altman's confidence in its potential has driven OpenAI's research and product development.

just technological but ethical: how can we build systems that can do incredible things without causing harm? This question has been a cornerstone of his leadership at OpenAI.

Altman has often framed AGI not only as a technological achievement but as a societal leap comparable to the development of electricity or the internet. He's been careful to point out that AGI must be developed in a way that it benefits everyone, not just a select few. In various forums, he's emphasised the need for a balanced approach—one that recognises AI's potential to solve complex problems but also prepares for its risks. This phi-



A critical element of Altman's vision was the ethical and societal impact of AI. His early speeches and interviews reflected a deep awareness of AI's transformative power and the ethical considerations surrounding its development. Unlike some technology leaders who focus purely on innovation, Altman has been outspoken about AI's dual-edged nature—its ability to benefit society greatly but also the risks it poses if not developed responsibly. In several interviews, Altman has articulated that the most significant challenge for AI isn't

philosophy of responsible innovation has been central to Altman's leadership and has set the stage for what would follow.

OpenAI: Non-profit to commercial giant

One of the most significant shifts under Altman's leadership was OpenAI's transition from a non-profit research organisation to a capped-profit model. OpenAI was founded in 2015 by a group of tech luminaries, including Elon Musk, Altman, and several others, as a non-profit entity with the mission of